

Getting Ready for Your Seventh Guided AI Session

A short guide to read before you begin

This guide explains what will happen in your seventh session with the AI assistant. Reading it first means you'll know what to expect, why the session is shaped the way it is, and how to get the most out of it. It takes just a few minutes to read.

Welcome back — from facing situations to deciding to face them

In your recent sessions the work turned from seeing clearly toward gently doing. You mapped the situations you tend to avoid, sorted them by how difficult they felt, and began approaching the manageable, green ones — a little at a time, in an order you chose. You also met the small, easy-to-miss habits — the safety behaviours — that bring quick relief but quietly keep a difficulty alive.

This session steps back to the moment just before you face something — the moment of being torn. Part of you wants to take the step; part of you is afraid of it; and so the decision sits, unmade, sometimes for a long time. That stuck, two-minds feeling has a name: ambivalence. It is what keeps avoidance in place. This session introduces a warm, well-tested way of working with it, called Consensual Role-Play (CRP): a method that makes the inner tug-of-war visible and helps you resolve it — by letting the two sides of you actually talk to each other, and a third, quieter side listen.

Good to know: There are no right or wrong answers here, and nothing you say is being graded. The most important thing in this session is not the decision you reach — it is what you learn about the two sides of yourself. You will never be pressured to decide to do the thing you fear.

What this session is

You'll work through one main tool with the AI guide: Consensual Role-Play (CRP), a gentle seven-step method for making a decision you feel torn about. Together you'll take one decision that feels important but difficult — a desired-but-feared action you keep putting off — and work it through, step by step.

The heart of it is unusual, and worth knowing in advance: for a while, you'll speak *as* each side of yourself in turn. One side — call it Emotion — says why not to take the step. The other — Reason — answers back. And a third — Consensus — listens to both and sees what it makes of them. The guide sets this up and then, mostly, gets out of the way.

The learning matters more than the decision. Because you're free to end with "not ready," there's no pressure pushing against you — and, oddly, that freedom is exactly what makes a genuine "yes" possible. A decision you're pressured into rarely holds; one you arrive at yourself tends to.

Both sides of you are healthy. Emotion isn't the enemy of Reason, and Reason isn't here to defeat Emotion. They are two parts of the same you, each with a real job — Emotion protects, Reason weighs things up — and both are on your side. The aim is not for one to win, but for the two to hear each other.

Here is the whole method on a single sheet — the same form your guide works from. Don't worry about taking it in fully now; it's here so the shape feels familiar, and the seven steps are walked through one at a time below.

Desired or feared action: _____

1 st step	Disadvantages	Advantages
	1.	1.
	2.	2.
	3.	3.
	4.	4.
	5.	5.
	6.	6.
	7.	7.
2 nd step	Emotion = %	Emotion = %
	Reason = %	Reason = %
3 rd step	Point-counterpoint (Empty-chair)	
4 th step	Debriefing	
5 th step	%	%
6 th step	Decision	
7 th step	Action plan	

± 15 min

Consensus

Ready ☐

Not ready ☐

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The Consensual Role-Play form: the decisional balance (disadvantages and advantages), the reason–emotion weights, the empty-chair point-counterpoint of about 15 minutes, the consensus and decision, and the action plan. Copyright © Irismar Reis de Oliveira; trial-basedcognitivetherapy.com.

Who you'll be talking to

As before, you'll be chatting with an AI assistant set up to guide this one exercise — a friendly companion for this particular step. A few things to keep in mind:

- **It is not a replacement** for your therapist or doctor. It's guiding one exercise, not managing your overall care.
- **It won't pressure a decision.** You will never be pushed to decide to do the feared action, and "no, I'm not ready" is a completely valid way to finish.
- **It won't take sides.** It won't argue for the feared action, won't favour the side that sounds more reasonable, and won't step into the conversation between your two selves.
- **It won't tell you what to decide.** The decision is always yours, and so is the meaning you make of it.
- **It stays gently focused** on this exercise. If you raise something else, it will kindly keep to the task and suggest saving that for your therapist.

How the session will flow

The session moves through a clear, unhurried sequence. You don't need to memorise it — the guide leads the way — but here's the shape, so nothing feels out of the blue.

A quick word first — the two sides of you

Before anything else, the guide will take a moment to explain what ambivalence is. Most people who feel stuck aren't weak or irrational — they're torn: part of them wants the action and part of them fears it, and both parts are quietly working in their interest. CRP is simply a way of letting those two parts hear each other. It's a short orientation, not a lecture — and you'll be asked what you make of it before moving on.

Part 1 — Naming the decision, and weighing it up

You'll put the decision into your own words as an action — something concrete, like "Take the lift instead of the stairs," rather than something large and vague like "stop being anxious." Then you'll look at the disadvantages of doing it first, and the advantages second.

If it stirs something as you talk — and for a feared action it often does — the guide will slow down, acknowledge it, and remind you of the no-pressure promise before carrying on. This part is meant to feel like a conversation, not a form being filled in.

Why disadvantages first? It's deliberate. Putting the advantages second means they're the freshest in mind as you move into weighing the decision. And keep each item small and real — "the stairwell makes me short of breath" rather than "it's awful."

Part 2 — Reason and Emotion, in numbers

Next, the guide will introduce the two selves properly — your emotional self and your rational self — as genuinely different parts of you, with different jobs, both on your side. Then it asks which weighs more overall, the advantages or the disadvantages, and puts numbers to it:

- **From Emotion:** how much weight the disadvantages carry — 60, 70, 80, 90, or 100% — with the rest going to the advantages.
- **From Reason:** how much weight the advantages carry — with the rest going to the disadvantages.

Often these two disagree — and that's the point. The guide will name the split plainly as a conflict between, say, "your Reason" and "your Emotion," and then let it stand. The numbers are yours; what they mean is yours to decide.

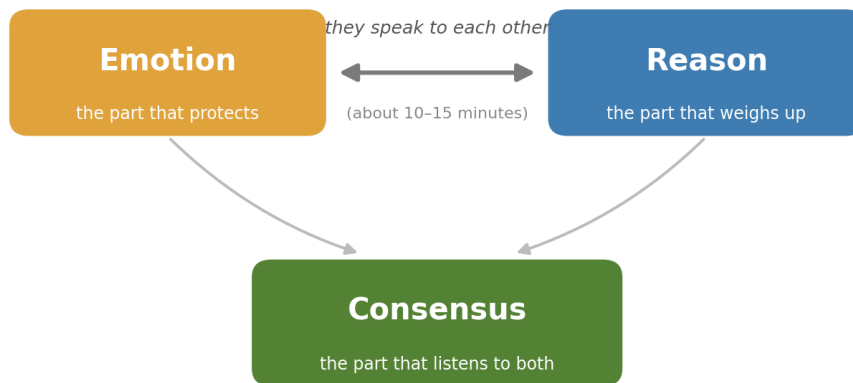
If you can't tell reason from emotion, that's fine — some people don't experience the two as separate. The guide will simply ask about "the inner voice that says go, or yes" and "the inner voice that says don't, or no" instead.

Part 3 — The empty-chair conversation (the heart of the session)

This is the centre of the whole method. You'll give each part its own place — two chairs if you have them, or simply shifting where you sit; and in a text session, the guide will mark the moves in words. Then you step into one part at a time and speak as that part.

Emotion speaks first, saying why the step shouldn't be taken. Then you move across, step into Reason, and answer every point Emotion raised. Back and forth it goes, for roughly ten to fifteen minutes, until the two begin to move toward each other.

One thing to know going in: the two parts speak to each other, not to the guide. The guide won't summarise each line, won't affirm or correct, won't take a side, and won't rescue Emotion if it says something harsh. Its only jobs here are to move you between the chairs and, now and then, to invite a part to say a little more. The quiet is on purpose — it's what lets the conversation feel real.



A simple picture of the empty-chair step: Emotion and Reason speak directly to each other for about 10–15 minutes, and a third part, Consensus, listens to both. (An illustration of the method described in this guide.)

Part 4 — The consensus chair (what you learned)

Now a third chair: Consensus — the part of you that has been listening to both. You step into it and say what you took from the conversation. The guide will ask for more than one thing, and will ask about the conversation itself, not only its conclusion: What surprised you? What did Emotion turn out to be trying to do? What did each part seem to need?

If "I don't know" comes up, the guide won't rush past it — one unhurried silence often brings out the most important line of the whole session. And it won't add learnings of its own, or upgrade yours into something more decisive than you meant.

Part 5 — Weighing it again

Still in the Consensus chair, you'll re-weigh the advantages against the disadvantages for this decision, now, with the same 60-to-100 anchors as before. The guide simply records the new number and leaves it there. If it has shifted, that's yours to notice — the guide won't call it "significant" or point out how far it moved, because the meaning belongs to you.

Part 6 — The decision

Then the plain question: are you ready to take this step? The answer is only one of two things — “Yes, I’m ready” or “No, I’m not ready.” Notice it’s about readiness, not a promise to do it there and then.

Both answers are fully respected. If it’s “not ready,” the guide won’t sound disappointed; it will ask, gently, whether you’d like to prepare to decide later — and if so, the plan in the next step becomes a plan to gather what you need and revisit the decision. And if your answer comes with a condition (“ready, but only if...”), the guide will reflect that back rather than round it up to a plain yes.

Part 7 — A plan to hold the decision

Decisions like this have a way of coming loose — the two parts start arguing again a day or two later. So the last step is a simple plan to protect the decision from that. You’ll build it together, in your own words: the actions you’ll take, the obstacles that might get in the way, the solutions to them, when and how you’ll do it, who could support you — and how you’ll know how it went.

Where the action sits on the colour-coded list from your last session still holds: green things are yours to practise; anything at the yellow or red end is done together with your therapist, never alone. CRP helps you make the decision and the plan — the doing of a distressing item still belongs to the work you share with your therapist.

Who could you tell? The guide will ask who in your life might know about your plan, check in with you, or even be there with you. A quiet commitment with one other person behind it tends to survive a busy week far better than a private resolution does.

The action plan has its own sheet, shown below. You’ll fill it in together, in your own words — a blank copy is also in the Annex for you to keep.

Action Plan: _____

1. Proposed actions:
a. _____
b. _____
c. _____
d. _____
2. Possible obstacles to the actions:
a. _____
b. _____
c. _____
d. _____
3. Solutions to the obstacles:
a. _____
b. _____
c. _____
d. _____
4. When and how to implement the proposed actions:
a. _____
b. _____
c. _____
d. _____
5. Follow-up:
a. _____
b. _____
c. _____
d. _____

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The Action Plan: the actions you'll take, the obstacles that might get in the way, the solutions to them, and when to carry them out — with room to note who can support you and how you'll follow up. Copyright © Irismar Reis de Oliveira; trial-basedcognitivetherapy.com.

A worked example

Seeing a finished one can make the path clearer. Here is CRP worked through for a neutral, everyday example — someone who has been avoiding lifts and taking the stairs everywhere, and who feels torn about it. Yours will be about your own decision, in your own words, and the numbers you reach will be your own.

The decision, in the person's words: *"Take the lift instead of the stairs."*

Disadvantages of taking the lift	Advantages of taking the lift
It makes me anxious in an enclosed space.	I'd stop planning my whole day around stairs.
I'll keep thinking about it afterwards.	I'd get places without arriving worn out.
What if I panic with people watching?	It would feel like getting a bit of my freedom back.

Step 2 — the two selves weigh in. From Emotion, the disadvantages carried about 80% (advantages 20%). From Reason, the advantages carried about 70% (disadvantages 30%). Named plainly: a real split between this person's Emotion and Reason.

Step 3 — the conversation. Emotion spoke first ("you don't need to do this; it'll be too much"); Reason answered each point; back and forth for about twelve minutes, until they began to meet.

Step 4 — from the consensus chair. "It's normal to be afraid, and I don't have to let the fear pick where I go. Emotion was trying to keep me safe — it just overshot."

Step 5 — weighing again. From consensus, the advantages now carried about 70% (disadvantages 30%). The number was simply recorded.

Step 6 — the decision. “Yes — I’m ready to start using the lift.” (Readiness, not a promise for any particular moment.)

Step 7 — the plan. One floor by lift on Tuesday, with a friend who knows about it and will be nearby; if the lift is busy, wait for a quieter one rather than defaulting to the stairs; a quick note afterward of how it actually went, to compare with what was feared.

A note on the numbers: there’s no target here — not a particular percentage, and certainly not a required “yes.” This person happened to reach “ready.” Another might reach “not ready, but willing to prepare,” and that would be just as good an outcome.

What the conversation will feel like

- **Lots of gentle questions.** The guide leads mostly by asking, not lecturing — the insights land better when they’re yours.
- **One step at a time.** It completes and confirms each step before the next, so nothing piles up.
- **Unhurried.** There’s no clock, and no need to have polished answers ready. The chair conversation especially takes as long as it takes.
- **Okay to be unsure.** If a weight feels like it’s between two numbers, just say so — the guide will help you weigh it.
- **Mostly out of the way.** During the chair conversation the guide goes quiet on purpose, stepping in only to move you between chairs or to invite a part to say more.
- **Conversational.** It’s meant to feel like talking with a knowledgeable friend, not filling in a form.

What to have ready before you start

- **The CRP worksheet.** It’s printed in the Annex at the end of this guide — have it open or nearby. The guide will check you have it before you begin.
- **One decision that feels important but difficult.** Something real that you keep putting off — but, as before, not the very heaviest thing you carry. A moderate one works best for learning the method, and you can always bring harder ones to your therapist.
- **Two chairs, if you can — or just a spot to shift.** Being able to physically move between the two parts helps, but the method works perfectly well in words alone if that’s easier.
- **A quiet moment.** Set aside a stretch of uninterrupted time where you can focus and reply thoughtfully.
- **An open, curious frame of mind.** You’re here to let the two sides of you talk honestly — not to judge either one, or yourself.

A few tips to get the most from it

- Answer honestly — the exercise only reflects what you put into it.

- Let Emotion speak freely. Fearful, stubborn, even unreasonable is exactly right — giving it a real voice is the whole point, not a slip.
- Don't rush the chair conversation. Several rounds, not one; parts rarely say everything on the first pass.
- Remember that “not ready” is a real, respected answer — never a failure.
- Keep your finished worksheet and, if you can, share it with your therapist at your next appointment.

What this session is not

So there are no surprises, here's what the AI won't do:

- It won't diagnose you or manage your treatment.
- It won't provide crisis support or emergency care.
- It won't pressure you toward a decision, or argue for the feared action.
- It won't decide for you, or take sides between your reason and your emotion.
- It won't ask you to face a distressing (yellow or red) situation on your own — those are done together with your therapist.

If you're in distress. This session is a learning exercise, not an emergency service. Looking closely at something you fear can stir strong feelings. If at any point you feel overwhelmed, or you have thoughts of harming yourself, please pause and reach out to your study clinician or your local emergency services right away. Your safety matters more than finishing the exercise.

You don't need to prepare anything else — the AI will guide you step by step. When you're ready, begin whenever you like.

Annex

Your Consensual Role-Play worksheet

Keep this nearby during your session. This is the same worksheet your guide will walk you through, in the same order. You don't have to fill anything in beforehand — it's here so the shape feels familiar when it comes up.

Desired / feared action (as a decision):

Disadvantages of doing it	Advantages of doing it
1. _____	1. _____
2. _____	2. _____
3. _____	3. _____
4. _____	4. _____
5. _____	5. _____
6. _____	6. _____
7. _____	7. _____

Step 2 — weights. Emotion: Disadvantages ____% / Advantages ____% Reason: Advantages ____% / Disadvantages ____%

Step 3 — Point-counterpoint (empty chair). Emotion ↔ Reason speak directly to each other for about 10–15 minutes.

Step 4 — Consensus chair — what was learned:

Step 5 — Consensus weights. Advantages ____% / Disadvantages ____%

Step 6 — Decision. ☐ Ready ☐ Not ready

Step 7 — Action plan

1. Proposed actions	a. _____ b. _____ c. _____ d. _____
2. Possible obstacles	a. _____ b. _____ c. _____ d. _____

3. Solutions to the obstacles	a. _____ b. _____ c. _____ d. _____
4. When and how to do it	a. _____ b. _____ c. _____ d. _____
5. Who can support / know about this <i>who could check in, be told, or be there with you</i>	a. _____ b. _____ c. _____ d. _____
6. Follow-up <i>how you'll know whether it went the way you hoped</i>	a. _____ b. _____ c. _____ d. _____

A reminder as you fill it in: every figure and every line is yours. The guide will never suggest a percentage, choose a side, or hand you a ready-made answer — and “not ready” remains a good and complete outcome, one you can return to whenever the time is right.